CHILDREN

Fawn in the wood

Unknown

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[Illustration: YELLOW DWARF SERIES

FAWN IN THE WOOD

McLOUGHLIN BROTHERS, N.Y.]

THE

FAWN IN THE WOOD.

[Illustration]

Once upon a time, there lived a King and Queen, who were very unhappy, because they had no children. But one day, when the Queen was walking out, she saw an immense crab, which said to her, “follow me, great Queen, and you shall have your wish.” The Queen was very much astonished at being thus addressed by the wonderful crab, and for a time hesitated as to what she should do. Her desire to have a child of her own, however, was so great, that it overcame her fears at last, and she determined to risk everything to gain her end. She therefore followed the crab through a secret path, until they reached a palace built of diamonds and pearls, in front of which stood six lovely fairies, who each presented her with a flower made of gems. There was a rose, a tulip, a lily, a pink, a camellia, and a dahlia.

[Illustration: Threat of the Fairy Crab.]

[Illustration: The Princess in her Secret Palace.]

“Madam,” said they, “you will soon have a daughter, whom you must call ‘Desired.’ As soon as she is born, summon us by repeating the name of each flower, and we will make her a miracle of grace and goodness.” The happy Queen returned home, and in due time, a little Princess was born. The fairies were sent for, and after kissing the infant, they endowed her with wit, beauty, virtue, and every good quality they could think of. The grateful Queen was just thanking them for their kindness, when there entered a crab, so large that it could scarcely get through the door. “Ah, wicked Queen,” it said, “you have forgotten the service I rendered you, in guiding you to my sisters; you have called _them_, and neglected _me_.” The Queen asked her pardon for the oversight, and her sister fairies joined their prayers to hers, but in vain. “I will not do _all_ the harm I intended,” said the crab, “but I warn you, if the Princess sees the light of day before she is fifteen, it will, perhaps, cost her her life!” Her parents were much alarmed at this threat, and at length determined to build a palace, without windows, and there to keep her until she was past the fatal age. This was done, and the Princess grew in knowledge and beauty until she was within a few months of being fifteen, having never seen any light, except that from wax candles which burned night and day. As the time grew near for her release, her portrait was painted, and a copy sent to every court in the world. All who saw this picture admired it, and many high and mighty Princes asked the hand of the young Princess in marriage; but _one_ of them fell so deeply in love with her as almost to lose his reason. His name was Warrior, and he was the son of a great King, whose court was not far from the country of the Princess Desired. Prince Warrior begged his father to send an ambassador to the Princess, and an eloquent nobleman, called Silvertongue,

was selected.

As soon as he arrived at the court of the Princess, he requested to see her, but to his great surprise, that favor was denied him. “Do not be offended, Lord Silvertongue,” said the King, “at our refusal of a request which you are perfectly justified in making,” and he then related to the nobleman the whole of the wonderful story. Silvertongue then took leave of the King, and returned to his own court. Great was the anguish of Prince Warrior when he found that he could not see the Princess for three long months--for she still lacked that much of being fifteen years old.

The King, his father, was in despair, and Lord Silvertongue was sent back at his utmost speed, to assure the parents of Desired that Prince Warrior would surely die if they refused him their daughter any longer. Now, the Princess had seen Prince Warrior’s portrait, and was as much in love as he was; so when her mother went to see her, and told her of the illness of the young Prince, she was very much affected, and said: “Dearest mother, could not I go in a coach so tightly closed that I couldn’t see daylight, and so reach my dear Prince Warrior in safety?” The King and Queen were well pleased at this idea, and Lord Silvertongue immediately returned with the news to Prince Warrior.

A coach was built, lined with pink and gold brocade, but without glass windows, and a great nobleman was given charge of it. Then the Princess was locked up in the coach, in company with her two ladies-in-waiting--Clove-Flower, and Long-Nails--and at once set out, with a strong escort, for the court of Prince Warrior.

Now, you must know that Clove-Flower was very fond of her mistress; but Long-Nails, who was very much in love with Prince Warrior herself, from having seen his picture, was determined to destroy her mistress if she could, and try to gain the Prince for herself. So on the last day of the journey, when they were near the court of the young Prince, Long-Nails suddenly cut open the roof of the coach, with a large knife, and for the first time in her life, Princess Desired saw the light of day! The moment the light touched her, she sprang from the coach with a sad cry, and in the form of a beautiful white Fawn, bounded into the forest, and hid herself in a dark and gloomy thicket!

[Illustration]

The wicked old Crab-Fairy, who had caused all this, seemed bent upon the destruction of the world. The thunder and lightning was so terrible; that all the attendants ran away in their fright, except Long-Nails and her mother; and Clove-Flower, who ran after the Princess. Long-Nails then dressed herself in the Princess’ richest clothes and jewels, and followed by her mother, set out for the city, and were soon met by the King and his son. But the moment Prince Warrior saw her, he fell back with a loud cry: “What do I see?” said he. “Sire,” said Long-Nails’ mother boldly; “_this_ is the Princess Desired,” (pointing to her wicked daughter,) with letters and presents from the King and Queen.

The Prince, with his eyes still fixed upon Long-Nails, who was as ugly as Desired was beautiful, cried in a loud voice: “I am betrayed; this is not the Princess Desired.” Then waving his hand, two of the soldiers seized upon the false Princess and her

mother, and locked them up in one of the strong castles of the city. Prince Warrior was so overcome by the shock, that he determined to leave the court secretly; and with no companion but his faithful Silvertongue, spend the remainder of his life in exile. They left the court at once, and the next day found themselves in a vast forest, where the Prince dismounted, while Silvertongue went to look for food.

We must now return to the unhappy Fawn. Clove-Flower, as you know, pursued her; and as soon as the Fawn saw her, she ran up eagerly and caressed her, while the tears flowed from her lovely eyes. Clove-Flower saw at once that the Fawn was her dear mistress. Just then the fairy Tulip, who had been at the birth of the Princess, and pitied her sad condition, appeared on the scene. Clove-Flower entreated the fairy to restore the Princess to her natural form. “I cannot do _that_,” said she, “but I can soften her punishment. When night comes, she will regain her form, until the morning, when she must again roam the fields and forests. Proceed by this path till you come to a cottage where you can get food and shelter.”

They followed her directions, and soon found the cottage, where a nice old woman gave them an inner room, in which were two pretty beds. As soon as night came, Desired ceased to be a Fawn; and they lay down in each other’s arms, and slept with many tears. But as soon as it was daylight, the Princess became a Fawn once more; and at once left the cottage, and fled into the woods. Meanwhile, Silvertongue had arrived at the cottage, in search of food, where the old woman not only filled a basket for him, but offered them a shelter for the night, which he accepted.

The Prince slept badly, and as soon as it was morning, _he_ also went out into the wood; and after wandering about sadly for a long time, began to feel weary, and lay down under a tree to rest. He soon fell asleep, and began to dream of the lost Princess. Just then the White Fawn came to the same spot, and as she looked at the sleeping Prince, (whom, of course, she knew at once from his picture;) she could not help heaving a deep sigh of love and despair! The Prince was awakened by the sound, and springing up with surprise, fitted an arrow to his bow; and as the frightened Fawn flew swiftly away in the wood, he let fly the arrow from the string; which wounded her slightly in the leg, and brought her panting and bleeding to the ground.

[Illustration: Prince Warrior Wounding the Fawn.]

[Illustration: The Prince Captures the Fawn.]

The Prince soon came up, and when he saw the look of fear and pain in her soft eyes, his heart was moved to pity; and he was sorry for what he had done. He caressed her tenderly, and gathering some herbs, bound them around her leg; and then making her a soft bed of leaves, he went to look for Silvertongue, to assist him in getting the Fawn to the cottage. As soon as the Prince was out of sight, Clove-Flower, who had been looking for her mistress, came up in great distress, and was trying to get the Fawn upon her feet, when the Prince and Silvertongue returned, and claimed her as their own. “My lord,” said Clove-Flower, “this Fawn belonged to me, before she did to you; and I would sooner lose my life than her;” and upon this, the Prince at once gave her up to Clove-Flower, and assisted her in carrying the Fawn to the cottage.

Silvertongue then told the Prince that he had seen Clove-Flower at the court of, and in attendance upon, Desired. The Prince was amazed, and to satisfy himself, made a small hole in the wall, and looked through. It was now after dark, and the Princess had regained her form. She lay on the bed weeping sadly, and saying with many sighs: “Alas! must I become a Fawn again, and see him whom I love, without being able to speak to him.” This was enough. They knocked gently at the door, and in a moment the Prince was at the Princess’ feet, declaring his love and devotion. Just then the noise of trumpets was heard without, and the King, who was searching for his son, entered the cottage.

All this was brought about by the fairy Tulip. _She_ was the old woman, and the cottage was _hers_. The Princess was carried to the court of Prince Warrior in a close carriage, and kept in darkness until she reached the age of fifteen, which was now close at hand. The marriage was then celebrated with great splendor, and was rendered more brilliant by the presence of the six fairies who had presided at her birth; and by the wedding of Silvertongue and Clove-Flower, who were married at the same time.

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Transcriber's Note:

Three misspelled words and nine punctuation marks were corrected.